

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

As British scientist Peter Whibberley has observed, “the Earth is not a very good timekeeper.” Earth’s slightly irregular rotation rate means that measurements of time must be periodically adjusted. Specifically, an extra “leap second” (the 86,401st second of the day) is _____ time based on the planet’s rotation lags a full nine-tenths of a second behind time kept by precise atomic clocks.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. added, whenever
- B. added; whenever
- C. added. Whenever
- D. added whenever

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a verb and a preposition. When, as in this case, a verb (“is added”) is immediately followed by a preposition (“whenever”), no punctuation is needed.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and the preposition. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and the preposition. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb and the preposition.